Hurricane and Spitfire
A Hurricane fighter (foreground) flies with a Spitfire during World War II. Though the Spitfire is better known, the Hurricane was more numerous, and so had the higher strike record against the Luftwaffe.

Instead of mounting air patrols, the RAF pilots waited near their aircraft on the ground, ready to "scramble" at a moment's notice. Coastal radar stations alerted control centres to the approach of enemy aircraft; controllers ordered squadrons into the air. The fighters were then given radioed instructions to guide them towards the enemy.

GETTING AIRBORNE

Scrambling always had to be carried out with utmost speed, because every second of delay would translate into less altitude gained before meeting the enemy. At worst, squadrons stationed at airfields close to the south coast ran the risk of being caught on the ground. Consequently, pilots set off for their aircraft at a run. It typically took five minutes for a squadron to get airborne. There were cases of men caught unprepared taking off wearing flying gear over pyjamas.



Eagle Squadron pilot
Due to a shortage of pilots after the Battle of Britain, the RAF recruited volunteers from overseas to make up their numbers. The Eagle Squadrons were made up of US recruits.

The pilot was squeezed into a tight cockpit under a Plexiglass hood, with his feet on the rudder bar, his right hand on the control stick, and his left hand on the throttle. There was virtually no space at all for body movement; to look around, the pilot could only turn his neck or his aircraft. In the air, he was expected to take his place in a tight V-shaped "vic" formation of three aircraft, which would usually be combined with other "vics" in a squadron of 12. For less experienced pilots, simply keeping formation was a demanding activity that left no time for watching the enemy. Although higher command insisted on this tight formation flying, experienced pilots increasingly took the initiative and abandoned the "vics". The better squadrons adopted a loose formation and acted on the principle of engaging the enemy as aggressively as possible whenever and in whatever way might work.

The Luftwaffe force typically consisted of a bomber swarm accompanied by Messerschmitt fighter escorts either in close attendance or at high altitude. The fighters had learned during the Spanish Civil War to base their formation on a pair of aircraft: a leader and a wingman. The leader was the senior pilot and the best shot; his wingman was supposed to guard his tail. Two such pairs would join together to make a loose "finger-four" formation. The four aircraft flew at slightly different altitudes and relatively spread out, so that they did not need to worry about the risk of collision. The looser formation also made the aircraft more difficult to spot.

The worst scenario for the RAF was to be "bounced" by the Messerschmitts. If they failed to spot the Luftwaffe fighters high above them, the latter would attack in a high-speed dive, picking on aircraft at the back of the British formation. It is reckoned that four out of five RAF pilots shot down never saw their attacker. Exploiting the momentum of the dive, the Messerschmitts could escape before any of the RAF fighters reacted. If the German fighters were spotted in time, the RAF pilots could turn to engage them and a "dogfight" ensued – a general mêlée with aircraft chasing one another in tight turns and firing in short bursts at any enemy in their sights. Dogfights were mostly brief but shatteringly intense and chaotic.